PRE-COLUMBIAN WARRIORS

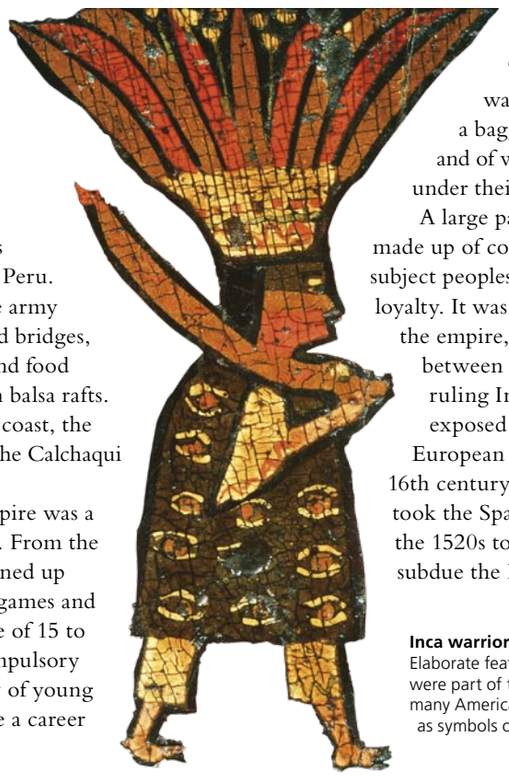
Before the arrival of Europeans at the end of the 15th century, the peoples of the Americas had a culture of warfare that had developed independently across thousands of years. In the absence of the horse and of any form of artillery, pre-Columbian forces consisted exclusively of infantry. Weapons were primarily of wood and stone. Many societies had a warrior aristocracy that commanded on the battlefield, dressed in elaborate decorative costumes. One of the principal aims of warfare was the taking of prisoners for use as slaves or as victims of religious sacrifice. Some states, notably the Aztecs and Incas, assembled substantial armies which enabled them to exert political and military control over large areas that had previously been independent chiefdoms.

THE INCAS

In the second half of the 15th century the Incas established an extensive empire in western South America stretching from northern Ecuador to central Chile. The creation of the empire was largely due to the military skills of the Incas' tenth ruler, Topa Inca (reigned 1471–93) who led campaigns of conquest both before and after ascending the throne. His military operations showed a rare degree of organizational skill. On one occasion, for example, the south of the empire was threatened by the Calchaqui people from northern Argentina crossing the mountains to the Pacific coast. Topa Inca marched his forces 1,000km (600 miles) down the Andes from his capital at Cuzco in Peru. Engineers went ahead of the army building mountain roads and bridges, while supplies of weapons and food were carried south by sea on balsa rafts. Resupplied on reaching the coast, the Inca army threw itself upon the Calchaqui and defeated them in battle.

At its height the Inca empire was a thoroughly militaristic state. From the age of 12, boys were toughened up with a routine of strenuous games and exercise. Then, from the age of 15 to 20, they had to perform compulsory military service. A minority of young conscripts stayed on to make a career in the army and a few achieved high position as a reward for conspicuous bravery. The Inca bureaucracy ensured that the army was well fed and clothed. The most common weapons were the slingshot and the stone-edged spear or axe. Members of the Inca clan, who constituted the nobility of the empire and made up the higher command of the army, sometimes carried axes of bronze. On campaign they would march alongside their ruler, who was carried on a litter. The Inca army was accompanied by a baggage train of llamas, and of women bowed down under their enormous loads.

A large part of the army was made up of contingents from subject peoples, some of doubtful loyalty. It was dissension within the empire, and civil war between members of the ruling Inca clan itself, that exposed the empire to European conquest in the 16th century. Nonetheless, it took the Spanish 50 years, from the 1520s to the 1570s, to fully subdue the Inca people.



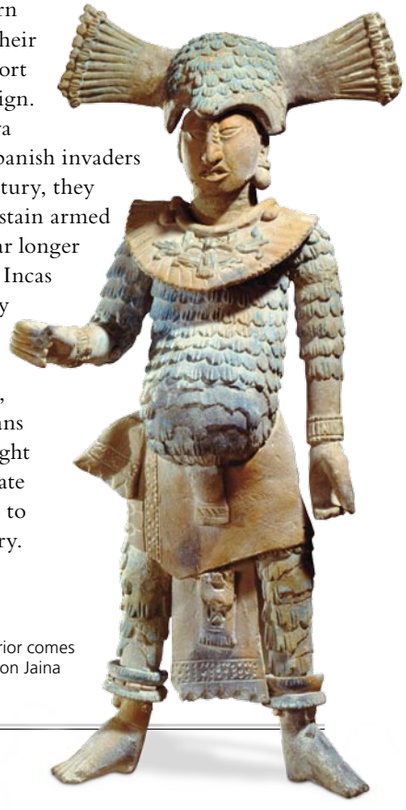
Inca warrior
Elaborate feathered headdresses were part of the war costume of many American peoples, serving as symbols of warrior status.

> "COME LET US EAT, AND COME LET US DRINK ... LET US EAT AND DRINK OF THE BLOOD AND THE BONES OF OUR ENEMY."
>
> INCA WAR CHANT

THE MAYA

The Maya civilization of eastern Central America, which reached its peak in around 250 to 900 CE, was once thought to have been averse to warfare. But in recent years historians have revised their opinions, concluding that the Maya fought wars of conquest and took prisoners to use as slaves and for ritual sacrifice.

The bulk of their forces were probably peasant militia led by warriors drawn from royal and noble families. Temple wall paintings show armies with splendid regalia – warriors decked out in masks and plumes, carrying standards and shields decorated with religious symbols. More prosaically, soldiers were equipped with quilted jackets as armour and carried a range of edged and missile weapons, including spears, stone-bladed wooden axes, throwing sticks, slingshots and bows. It is assumed that conflicts were brief, if bloody, since the peasant militia would have needed to return home to tend their crops after a short spell on campaign. When the Maya encountered Spanish invaders in the 16th century, they were able to sustain armed resistance for far longer than either the Incas or Aztecs. They were not fully subjugated until the 1690s, and rebel Mayans continued to fight the Mexican state from the 1840s to the 20th century.



Tomb fighter
This terracotta warrior comes from a Maya tomb on Jaina island, off Yucatan.